



LIVING *with* BANKRUPTCY

In 1980, there were just under 300,000 personal bankruptcies in our country. In 1990, there were more than 700,000, and in 2000, there were more than 1.2 million, according to the American Bankruptcy Institute. A tougher bankruptcy law, enacted in 2005, brought personal bankruptcy filings down to less than 600,000 the following year, but by 2008, personal bankruptcies had again crossed the 1 million mark.

A growing number of personal bankruptcies spells great difficulty for many smaller merchants and for the credit industry as a whole. But even more important, it reflects a decline in the responsibility index for the average American family, both Christian and non-Christian alike. Bankruptcies aren't limited to non-Christians. In fact, the percentage of Christians in bankruptcy appears to be about the same as that of the population in general, although accurate statistics are not readily available. I do know that an informal survey in almost any local church reveals a percentage approximating the national average.